Lesson 25: Body Paragraphs

English Stage 3 (C1) · Unit 3: Paragraphs, Essays and Cohesion

Adapted from College ESL Writers: Applied Grammar and Composing Strategies for Success by Barbara Hall and Elizabeth Wallace, Georgia State University - Perimeter College (CC BY-NC-SA): 4.5 Writing Body Paragraphs; 4.6 More About the Basic Elements of a First Draft; and Reading, Writing, Research, and Reasoning: An Advanced ESL Text by Gabriel Winer and Elizabeth Wadell, ASCCC Open Educational Resources Initiative (CC BY-NC 4.0): 2.5 Writing Body Paragraphs.

In this lesson

You learn how body paragraphs carry the evidence for your thesis: choosing your strongest points, turning them into topic sentences, and building each paragraph from evidence, analysis and a concluding sentence. You compare a confusing and a revised paragraph about stereotypes, then draft the body of your essay. In university essays, most of the marks depend on how well the body supports the claim.

Learning goals

After this lesson you should be able to:

- Select primary support that is specific, relevant and detailed.
- Write topic sentences that state a topic and a controlling idea and connect to the thesis.
- Identify kinds of evidence: facts, judgments, testimony, personal observation, textual evidence and personal experience.
- Write analysis that explains how the evidence supports the topic sentence and the thesis.
- Decide where a topic sentence goes and how long a paragraph should be.

Key language

Word or phrase	Meaning	Example
primary support	the major points you choose to support your thesis; each one becomes a topic sentence	three of your most compelling reasons
topic sentence	the sentence that states the paragraph's one point: a topic and a controlling idea	"Stereotypes are problematic because they give an incomplete view of a person within a group."
controlling idea	the writer's view of the topic	"... because they give an incomplete view of a person within a group"
judgment	a conclusion drawn from facts by careful reasoning	more credible than an opinion

Word or phrase	Meaning	Example
testimony	direct quotations from an eyewitness or an expert witness	an expert adds authority and credibility
textual evidence	evidence from outside sources	books, journals, TED talks
analysis (commentary)	your thinking about the evidence: you interpret, explain or comment on it	"People tend to make assumptions about the single story they hold of a particular group."
concluding sentence	the last sentence; it reminds the reader of the paragraph's main point	"Thus, stereotypes are 'incomplete' and can lead to prejudice ..."
implied topic sentence	a main idea that is not stated; readers must work it out	best avoided by developing writers
compelling	convincing and powerful	"Choose at least three of only the most compelling points."

Rules and explanations

From the thesis to the body

- Your thesis and outline are a **roadmap**; the body paragraphs follow it. A reader should be able to predict the body paragraphs from the thesis.
- **Primary support** is the set of major points you choose to argue for your thesis. Each point becomes the topic sentence of one body paragraph, and supporting details develop it.
- Good primary support is:
  - **specific**: narrow, concrete examples are more compelling than general, obvious ones;
  - **relevant**: it relates directly to the thesis; do not include everything you found;
  - **detailed**: the thesis is not detailed, but the body paragraphs develop the full discussion.
- To find it, prewrite, delete ideas that do not relate directly to your argument, and keep at least three of the most compelling points.

The four parts of a body paragraph

Part	What it does
Topic sentence	States one point; usually the first sentence. Arguable and specific (like a thesis), clear and in your own words: do not start it with a quotation or paraphrase. It can refer back to the previous paragraph.
Evidence	Supports the topic sentence. **Textual evidence** comes from outside sources (books, journals, websites, newspapers, magazines, TED talks, documentary films): facts, statistics and examples, given as a quote, paraphrase or summary. **Personal experience** can illustrate a point and works best with other evidence. Always credit the source.
Analysis	Your thinking: you interpret and explain the evidence and connect it to the topic sentence and the thesis.

Part	What it does
Concluding sentence	Reminds the reader of the paragraph's main point; it may hint at the topic of the next paragraph.

Questions that help you write analysis: How is this idea related to my thesis? What conclusions can I draw? What does this information imply? What are the consequences of thinking this way? How does it happen? Can I give an example? How might this evidence relate to other texts?

Kinds of evidence (Hall and Wallace)

Kind	What it is
Facts	The best evidence, because they often cannot be disputed. Some still need explanation: "The most populated state in the United States is California" must be made relevant to your argument.
Judgments	Conclusions drawn from facts through careful reasoning; more credible than opinions.
Testimony	Direct quotations from an **eyewitness** (direct experience; adds authenticity) or an **expert witness** (extensive experience with the topic; adds authority and credibility).
Personal observation	Your own testimony: what you know from experience, for example being one of five children in an essay about large families.

Where does the topic sentence go?

- In college writing, every paragraph has a topic sentence, usually first. In a persuasive essay it should be first.
- It can come last in order of importance or chronological order (the details build up to it), or in the middle in spatial order (descriptions come first).
- An **implied** topic sentence is not written at all. Developing writers should avoid it.
- Check your draft: highlight each topic sentence. If it contains information that the paragraph does not discuss, rewrite it.

Length and the first draft

- A paragraph should be "long enough" to explain your point: more than one sentence, shorter than one double-spaced page. A long paragraph is fine if it stays focused; if it becomes too long, divide it and start the new part with a topic sentence or a transition.
- Write at least three body paragraphs. Follow your outline: a Roman numeral (I, II) becomes a topic sentence, capital letters become supporting details, and Arabic numerals become subpoints.

Psychology note: in psychology papers, the main evidence is published research (studies and their data), cited in APA style (author, year). Personal observation is rarely used as evidence, except in reflective assignments.

> **Note for Arabic speakers** - Arabic often joins many clauses with "and" (wa). In a body paragraph, keep the evidence and your analysis in separate, clear sentences, and show the links

> with transitions instead of a long chain of "and". - Credit every source and put its exact words in quotation marks: copying source wording without them is plagiarism, even in a draft.

Practice

Exercise 1. A confusing paragraph. Read the first body paragraph about stereotypes ("Notice this!"), written for the thesis "The problem with stereotypes is not that they are untrue, but that they are incomplete, and make one story become the only story."

1. What three problems does the book find in this paragraph?
2. Which sentence could be the paragraph's main point? Where is it?
3. Now compare the revised paragraph ("Try this!"). Find three changes that introduce or credit the evidence better.

Exercise 2. The parts of the revised paragraph. In the revised paragraph, find: (a) the topic sentence, its topic and its controlling idea; (b) the evidence; (c) the analysis; (d) the concluding sentence.

Exercise 3. Topic and controlling idea. Give the topic and the controlling idea of each topic sentence.

1. In the STEM field, stereotypes persist that attribute girls' achievements to diligence instead of talent.
2. Stereotypes are problematic because they give an insufficient view of a person within a group.
3. Recognizing your stereotypes and the potential damage they do is the first step in creating change.

Exercise 4. Kinds of evidence. Items 1-5: fact, judgment, testimony (eyewitness or expert) or personal observation? Items 6-7: textual evidence or personal experience?

1. "The most populated state in the United States is California."
2. You are one of five children, and you use your own life to support the thesis that being part of a large family is beneficial to a child's social development.
3. A direct quotation from a researcher who has studied the topic for many years.
4. A direct quotation from a person who saw an event happen.
5. "Due to a lack of exposure, Akinola's students were probably expecting to see an old white male or possibly a white female professor instead of a young African-American female professor."
6. A point from Jennifer Eberhardt's TED talk.
7. Your memory of how you felt before your first presentation in English.

Exercise 5. Placing the topic sentence. According to Hall and Wallace, where would the topic sentence probably go in a paragraph (1) in a persuasive essay; (2) in order of importance; (3) that begins by describing a place (spatial order); (4) that tells events in time order?

Exercise 6. Primary support. Choose one working thesis from the book. Prewrite for five minutes, choose your three most compelling points, and write a topic sentence for each.

1. Unleashed dogs on city streets are a dangerous nuisance.

2. Students cheat for many different reasons.
3. Drug use among teens and young adults is a problem.
4. The most important change that should occur at my college or university is _____.

Speak with your tutor

- "Here is my outline: [paste]. Which of my primary support points are the most compelling? Is any of them too general or not relevant to my thesis?"
- "Here is one of my body paragraphs: [paste]. Label each sentence as topic sentence, evidence, analysis or concluding sentence. Where is my analysis too thin?"
- "Here is a quotation I want to use: [paste]. Ask me the lesson's analysis questions, one at a time, and push me to say more."
- "Check my answers to Exercises 1 and 3."

Read aloud

Pause briefly at each slash (/).

1. Stereotypes are problematic / because they give an incomplete view of a person within a group.
2. In the STEM field, / stereotypes persist that attribute girls' achievements to diligence / instead of talent.
3. Recognizing your stereotypes and the potential damage they do / is the first step in creating change.
4. People tend to make assumptions / about the single story they hold of a particular group.
5. Thus, / stereotypes are "incomplete" / and can lead to prejudice.

Writing task

Draft the body paragraphs of the essay you started in Lesson 24, following your outline from Lesson 23. If you chose a new topic, first write a thesis and three primary support points: for example, stereotypes and the "single story" (the book's topic), or a PSYC 110 topic such as sleep and memory, or stress and coping. For evidence, use free sources: the OpenStax textbook *Psychology 2e*, Google Scholar, PubMed Central or the Directory of Open Access Journals.

- Write at least three body paragraphs of about 120 to 220 words each.
- Each paragraph needs a topic sentence (topic and controlling idea, linked to the thesis), evidence with its source credited, at least two sentences of analysis, and a concluding sentence.

Self-editing checklist:

- Does each topic sentence state one point of my thesis, with a topic and a controlling idea, in my own words?
- Does every sentence in the paragraph relate to its topic sentence?
- Is my evidence specific, relevant and detailed, and is every source credited?

- Do I introduce each piece of evidence (who said it, and where)?
- Does my analysis explain how the evidence supports the topic sentence and the thesis?
- Does each paragraph end with a concluding sentence?
- When I highlight my topic sentences, do they match my outline and my thesis?

Paste your draft into the chat and ask your tutor for feedback. Then rewrite it.

Watch online

- Chimamanda Ngozi Adichie, "The Danger of a Single Story" (TED talk used in the model paragraph): https://www.ted.com/talks/chimamanda_ngozi_adichie_the_danger_of_a_single_story
- Jennifer L. Eberhardt, "How Racial Bias Works — and How to Disrupt It" (TED talk cited in the model paragraph): https://www.ted.com/talks/jennifer_l_eberhardt_how_racial_bias_works_and_how_to_disrupt_it

Answer key

Exercise 1

1. It lacks a clear topic sentence; the supporting evidence is not sufficiently introduced; there is no clear concluding sentence. (book)
2. "Stereotypes are 'incomplete' and can lead to prejudice as Adichie points out in her TED talk." It is hidden in the middle (the fourth sentence). The revision uses this idea to open and to close the paragraph.
3. The source is named ("In her TED talk 'The Danger of a Single Story,' ..."); the example is introduced as an example of the point ("An example of this kind of stereotyping is ...") instead of "Adichie cites the example of ..."; a citation is added ("(Akinola)"). (The revision also adds a topic sentence, adds a sentence of analysis, "People tend to make assumptions ...", and moves the "incomplete" sentence to the end as the concluding sentence.)

Exercise 2 (book)

- (a) "Stereotypes are problematic because they give an incomplete view of a person within a group." Topic: stereotypes. Controlling idea: they are problematic because they give an incomplete view of a person within a group.
- (b) From "In her TED talk 'The Danger of a Single Story,' Adichie argues ..." to "... what a professor should look like in the U.S (Akinola)."
- (c) From "People tend to make assumptions ..." to "... which may cause confusion."
- (d) "Thus, stereotypes are 'incomplete' and can lead to prejudice as Adichie points out in her TED talk."

Exercise 3 The topic is the same in all three: stereotypes (book). Controlling ideas:

1. In STEM, they attribute girls' achievements to diligence instead of talent.
2. They are problematic because they give an insufficient view of a person within a group.
3. Recognizing them and their potential damage is the first step in creating change.

Exercise 4

1. Fact (book).
2. Personal observation (book).
3. Testimony: an expert witness.
4. Testimony: an eyewitness.
5. Judgment: a conclusion the writer draws from the facts ("probably"). In Winer and Wadell's terms, it is part of the analysis.
6. Textual evidence (TED talks are one of the book's examples).
7. Personal experience.

Exercise 5 (1) First. (2) It may be last. (3) It may be in the middle. (4) It may be last.

Exercise 6 (example answer, thesis 2)

- Many students cheat because they feel strong pressure to earn high grades.
- Poor time management leads some students to cheat when a deadline arrives and the work is not finished.
- Some students cheat because they believe that "everyone does it" and that they will not be caught.

My notes